

CASE FILE

GHOST IN THE PROTOCOL

Seven suspects. **One query** away from the truth.

DATATHON



Datathon Notebook

Handle with Curiosity.
Solve with Logic.

Case No.
TC-2025-315

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The Premise (The Scene)

Meridian City. March 17th. 07:15 Local Time.

Meridian Technologies — a company worshipped by investors, feared by competitors — is three weeks from launching Prometheus, a revolutionary AI platform.

Its Chief Architect, Dr. Arjun Voss, is found dead in Room 404, server wing. Gun in hand. Door locked from inside. Note on the desk.

"I can't carry the weight anymore. The launch will fail. I'm sorry." — A.V.

Ruled suicide. But the math doesn't add up.



INITIAL ANOMALIES LOGGED

001 — Handedness. Voss favored his left hand for fine motor work. The weapon was found near his right — with no propellant residue on either palm consistent with self-infliction.

002 — The Chair. Rotated 22° from his known resting posture, with fresh drag marks in the carpet pile.

003 — The Note. Suspiciously clean prints. No smudging. Paper stock reserved for executives only — stock Voss had not requisitioned in three weeks.

004 — The Upload. A scan of the note hit the evidence server 21 minutes after estimated time of death — carrying a hidden string referencing Prometheus's internal kill-switch.



"YOUR FIRM IS NO MERE ANALYTICS AGENCY. YOU ARE THE LAST LINE OF TRUTH WHEN THE CODE LIES."

The Investigators



CAPT. HELENA WARD

Head, Precinct Digital Forensics Unit. | Age 51

Calm, low-voiced, intimidatingly controlled. Believes patterns matter more than statements. Distrustful of any system she can't audit by hand.

Habit: writes every timeline by hand.



DET. MARCUS REED

Lead Homicide Detective | Age 38

Rough, sarcastic, instinct-driven. Was dismissive of digital forensics — until the data started talking. Paces the room when a timeline won't close.

Habit: cheap coffee, quitting smoking weekly.



DR. LEILA HASSAN

Director of Digital Forensics | Age 34

Hyper-logical, emotionally detached on the clock. Former ethical hacker. Reads metadata like other people read faces.

Quote: "Systems erase timestamps. Both leave scars."



OFFICER DANIEL CHO

Junior Cyber Crime Officer | Age 26

Curious, anxious, brilliant with systems. First major homicide case. Organizes files obsessively; looks up to Leila.

Habit: leaks hints during briefings.

Suspects

Seven Suspects. One Truth.



ALPHA | ADRIAN COLE

Fired ML Engineer | Age 36 | Height 6'2" | Rugged, long dark hair, leather jacket

Reason: Public grudge against Voss. Badge ghost-read on the server floor two nights before the murder.



BETA | SARAH CHEN

Senior Product Manager | Age 31 | Height 5'5" | Sharp features, black long hair

Reason: Hostile late-night exchanges with Voss. Ran validation tests on Prometheus he never approved.



GAMMA | NAOMI VEGA

Chief Financial Officer | Age 44 | Height 5'7" | Gold-rimmed glasses, immaculate attire.

Reason: Her signature appears on every suspicious shell-company transfer in the ledger.



DELTA | MIKE ROSS

Junior DevOps Engineer | Age 29 | Height 5'8" | Hoodie under jacket, sleep-deprived.

Reason: His credentials logged in two physical locations at once — zero latency between them.

Suspects

Seven Suspects. One Truth.



EPSILON | EVELYN CROSS

VP of Engineering | Age 47 | Height 5'11" | Platinum-blonde, tailored suits, never rushes.

Reason: A witness heard heels leaving the server wing at 06:45 – three floors from where her badge says she was.



ZETA | DANIEL MERCER

Head of Corporate Security | Age 45 | Height 6'3" | Military build, watches every exit

Reason: Edited the badge logs himself and can't fully explain the camera outage near Room 404.



ETA | ELENA RUIZ

Cleaning Supervisor | Age 52 | Height 5'4" | Worn uniform, cleaning cart, easy to overlook

Reason: She found the body and described the killer's heels – and her own son was flagged by Prometheus months ago, a flag never investigated.

OPERATION DETAILS

Be Ready

Agency Size

2-3 Investigators per unit

Mission Duration

One Day of Active Investigation

Tools

- SQL-First (Complex JOINS, subqueries, CTEs)
- Python-First (Pandas, custom logic, matplotlib)
- Hybrid

You must write your own logic. No black-box functions

"TRUST YOUR DATA. TRUST YOUR PARTNER."

Rounds: What You Must Deliver

ROUND I — THE COLD CASE

The precinct hands you the initial dossier. Seven names, seven motives, one body. Run exploratory analysis and establish a baseline ranking.

The Evidence — `evidence_day1.db`

7 critical tables (`access_logs`, `calendar_events`, `email_metadata`, `employees`, `financial_transactions`, `server_logs`, `slack_metadata`)

DELIVERABLES

1. Top 5 suspect ranking
2. Forensic MCQs
3. Fill-in-the-blanks (exact values from queries)

ROUND II — THE SMOKING GUN

Crypto wallets, shell companies, and deleted Slack DMs surface overnight. Somewhere in this file is the hand that pulled the trigger — and, separately, the mind that planned it. They may not be the same person.

The Evidence — `evidence_day2.db`

Adds: `crypto_wallet_txns`, `shell_companies`, `slack_dm_recovered`.

DELIVERABLES

1. Name the Killer
2. Name the Mastermind
3. Forensic MCQs
4. Fill-in-the-blanks (exact values from queries)

The Leaderboard

- The Precinct Command Board will display the current ranking of all agencies throughout the investigation.
- Rankings are determined by the points earned from evaluated submissions.
- Scores are not updated continuously and will only change when a submission has been reviewed.
- Agencies may move up or down the board as new submissions are processed.
- The leaderboard represents the latest official standings at that time.

WATCH THE TICKER. PACE YOURSELF. SUBMIT BEFORE TIME RUNS OUT.

EVALUATION PROTOCOL

Round 1 (30%) – The Filter

- Accuracy of suspect ranking
- Correct responses to MCQs
- Correct responses to fill-in-the-blanks
- Identification of relevant evidence and supporting findings

Round 2 (70%) – The War

- Correct identification of the Killer
- Correct identification of the Mastermind
- Accuracy of supporting evidence
- Ability to incorporate newly released evidence
- Consistency between conclusions and data findings

RULES



1. No Generative AI

The use of Generative AI tools, including but not limited to ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, DeepSeek, etc., is prohibited

2. No Unauthorized Devices

Mobile phones, tablets, smartwatches, or other communication-capable devices may not be used during active investigation periods.

3. Agency Isolation

Communication is permitted only between the two members of an agency and authorized event staff. Communication with other agencies is prohibited.

4. Database Integrity

evidence.db is read-only. Do not attempt to modify, inject, or corrupt the database.

5. Competition Systems Provided

All required software and computing resources will be provided by the organizers.

DISQUALIFICATION CRITERIA

- Attempting to modify, corrupt, or tamper with the competition database or provided systems.
- Plagiarism, collusion, or submission of work substantially copied from another agency.
- Receiving assistance from individuals outside the registered agency members or event staff.
- Use of prohibited tools, including Generative AI systems.
- Attempting to access hidden competition materials, answer keys, or unauthorized resources.
- Deliberately interfering with another agency's work, systems, or performance.
- Harassment, intimidation, misconduct, or any behavior deemed detrimental to the event environment.



Solve the Mystery

MISSION DATE

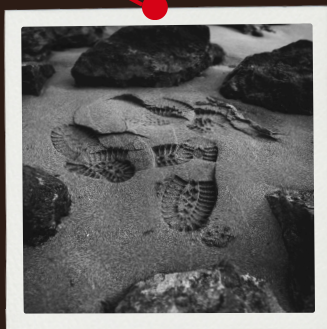
AUG 1st

INVESTIGATION ZONE

CCSIS, IoBM

OPERATION WINDOW

10:00 AM -
04:00 PM



FORENSIC COMMAND UNIT

FOR ANY QUERY, CONTACT THE UNIT BELOW

Areej Mazhar
std_34638@iobm.edu.pk

Javeria Sameen
std_34722@iobm.edu.pk

Abdur Rafay Ali
Khan
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Case Closed

- ghosts don't kill people.
- people with something to hide do.
- the truth is in the data.
- the rest is noise.

